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Examiners' Report
Summer 2026

GCSE History 1HI0 B4

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Introduction

Section B of Paper 2 assesses the British Depth Study and requires candidates to demonstrate both AO1 (Knowledge and Understanding) and AO2 (Analysis of Second-Order Concepts). In 2026, the B paper continued to be sat alongside the P paper for a combined total of 64 marks. The structural changes introduced in 2025 remained in place, including the revised format of Questions 1a and 1b and the extended total examination time.

Questions 1a and 1b are worth two marks each and follow the same format as the short-answer items on Paper 1. Candidates are required to describe one feature of two different topics and then develop each feature with a relevant detail or contextual point. These questions are designed to be accessible entry-level items and reward concise, accurate knowledge rather than extended explanation.

Question 2 is marked out of 12 and the mark scheme is an identical format to Q4 on Paper 1 and Q2 on Paper 3. It assesses the second order concept of causation. Two stimulus points are provided to prompt recall of studied content; however, they are not intended to represent complete causes in themselves. Candidates are not required to use the stimulus points and should avoid doing so if they do not recognise them. To access the top of Level 3 and Level 4, candidates must address three aspects of content, selecting precise knowledge and organising it into a clear line of reasoning.

For the final extended-response question, candidates choose either Question 3 or Question 4, each worth 16 marks. These questions may assess any second-order concept—such as significance, consequence, similarity/difference, or change and continuity—and follow the same principles as Q5/6 on Paper 1. As with Question 2, stimulus points are provided to support recall, but they are not compulsory and typically relate to aspects of content rather than discrete factors. Access to the higher levels requires both depth and breadth of knowledge, alongside a sustained and well-supported judgement.

Across the entry, many candidates demonstrated broad subject knowledge that supported Level 3 performance. Responses achieving Level 4 showed a secure grasp of the conceptual focus of the question and produced a supported judgement based on clear criteria, often sustained throughout the answer rather than appended as a final paragraph. While many Level 4 responses adopted a balanced structure, this is not a requirement; what matters is that the judgement directly addresses the conceptual focus of the question.

At Level 2, candidates typically presented a range of relevant content but struggled to apply it analytically to the second-order concept, often describing events rather than explaining their significance or causal impact. It remains essential that candidates read the question carefully and shape their response around the conceptual demand —whether causation, consequence, significance, similarity/difference, or change and continuity.

In the British Depth Study, Q1a and Q1b use a points-based mark scheme, while Q2, Q3 and Q4 are marked using a levels-of-response 'best fit' approach. Progression in AO1 is demonstrated through increasingly precise selection of information and wide-ranging knowledge. Progression in AO2 is shown through movement from simple or generalised comments to analytical explanation with a coherent, logical and sustained line of reasoning.

The indicative content in the mark scheme is illustrative rather than prescriptive. It does not represent a checklist of required material, nor does it dictate how candidates should structure their responses. Any valid analysis and accurate detail are credited, and examiners noted that many candidates demonstrated impressive knowledge and understanding that extended well beyond the indicative content.

Question 1

Question 1 on the paper consists of two 2–mark parts. Question 1(a) asked candidates to describe one feature of poverty in early Elizabethan England. In Question 1(b), candidates were asked to describe one feature of the colonisation of Virginia.

On Q1(a), candidates often wrote about the causes of poverty, perhaps due to this having been a 16–mark question on the 2025 paper. Common answers included references to population growth, enclosure, the decline of the wool trade, inflation and the impact of the dissolution of the monasteries: though out of period, its effects were still being felt during the reign of Elizabeth and thus this content was creditable. Other responses referred to the categorisation of different groups, such as the idle poor and the deserving poor, and there was some quite specific knowledge about specific types of poor, such as the Abraham-men, that seemed to have been drawn from original source material. Many candidates also wrote about vagabonds and their punishments; legislation around poverty; and differences in education and entertainment. These were all valid approaches.

Responses that wrote about crown debt were not rewardable. There were also a number of answers that referenced dirty cities and poor housing, likely drawing on content learned as part of the thematic study: these were also not rewardable.

The most common response to Q1(b) identified that colonisation in Virginia failed, backing this with a relevant key feature: poor planning, a late departure, the shipwreck of the *Tiger*, the composition of the settlers' party or the relations with the Indigenous people. A number of responses identified Raleigh as the expedition's planner, while a small number referenced other key figures such as Grenville, Lane and White. Though it is no longer part of the specification, some candidates wrote about the disappearance of the second expedition and this was credited.

This question, while generally well answered, was more likely to be left blank or incorrectly answered than Q1(a). Common errors included conflating Raleigh with Drake; writing about the circumnavigation or very generally about conflict with Spain; and describing motivation for exploration more generally.

In both questions, it was evident that the vast majority of candidates understood how to successfully structure their answers and did not spend too much time doing so, indicating that they had been well prepared by their teachers. A small minority of candidates presented two separate, undeveloped points and this was a common reason for losing the second mark.

1 (a) Describe **one** feature of poverty in early Elizabethan England.

(2)

There were 2 types of poor. These were the deserving and undeserving poor. The deserving poor consisted of sick, elderly or disabled and undeserving was those who chose not to work.

(b) Describe **one** feature of the attempted colonisation of Virginia.

(2)

They were unprepared for it as they brought too many soldiers and tradesmen and not enough farmers. They also brought no women.

(Total for Question 1 = 4 marks)

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Examiner Comments

These answers represent common approaches to both questions during this series. They identify a valid feature and provide accurate supporting evidence. This response scored full marks.

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Examiner Tip

Use key words you have learned as part of the course: for example, here the candidate has written about deserving and undeserving poor.

1 (a) Describe **one** feature of poverty in early Elizabethan England.

(2)

The poor couldn't afford healthcare so illness was spread through poorer neighbourhoods

(b) Describe **one** feature of the attempted colonisation of Virginia.

(2)

It didn't work

(Total for Question 1 = 4 marks)

ResultsPlus

Examiner Comments

The response to Q1a is general but valid for this question. It scored 1 mark. The response to Q1b is very brief, but it is accurate. This also scored 1 mark.

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Examiner Tip

It is always a good idea to write something for every question, even if it is very brief.

1 (a) Describe **one** feature of poverty in early Elizabethan England.

(2)

One feature Of Poverty in early Elizabethan England was the Poor ~~worked~~ would live on the Streets.

(b) Describe **one** feature of the attempted colonisation of Virginia.

(2)

One feature of the attempted colonisation of ~~D~~ Virginia was the lack of Supplies

(Total for Question 1 = 4 marks)

ResultsPlus

Examiner Comments

Both responses here represent a common approach taken by candidates, who use the language of the question but then do not support the identified feature with additional information.

ResultsPlus

Examiner Tip

Ensure that you support the feature identified with an additional fact: if you are short on time, begin right away with the fact, rather than copying the language of the question.

1 (a) Describe **one** feature of poverty in early Elizabethan England.

(2)

one feature of poverty was the idle poor. The idle poor were people that were too lazy to to try find work and would be given the death penalty.

(b) Describe **one** feature of the attempted colonisation of Virginia.

(2)

the people who already lived there were hostile towards the English. It angered them that Englishmen kept taking their food resources

(Total for Question 1 = 4 marks)

ResultsPlus

Examiner Comments

In each case, the candidate has identified a feature and then supported with a relevant fact and has scored full marks.

ResultsPlus

Examiner Tip

Responses to Q1 do not need to be overly detailed or specific.

1 (a) Describe **one** feature of poverty in early Elizabethan England.

(2)

The deserving poor were the elderly, disabled and widowed whilst the undeserving poor were the abebodied.

(b) Describe **one** feature of the attempted colonisation of Virginia.

(2)

Raleigh planned the expedition but didn't get to go.

(Total for Question 1 = 4 marks)

ResultsPlus

Examiner Comments

This final example is used in contrast with the previous example: it is briefer but the knowledge selected is very specific. These responses also scored 2+2 marks.

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Examiner Tip

Responses to Q1 can remain brief, as long as they are focused on the question.

Question 2

In Question 2, candidates were asked to explain why the Revolt of the Northern Earls was a threat to Elizabeth. They were given the stimulus points of Mary, Queen of Scots, and relations between England and Spain.

There were two common approaches: firstly, and more common, were answers that focused on the threat posed by the reasons for or ramifications of the Revolt, for example the religious divide, the desire to replace Elizabeth with Mary, Elizabeth's subsequent excommunication and further plots against her; and secondly, answers that focused on the events of the Revolt itself and why these were a threat to Elizabeth: the involvement of powerful noblemen such as the Duke of Norfolk, the scale of the revolt, the fact that it was a long way from London. It was not uncommon for responses to combine reasons from both of these approaches.

Responses that scored in Level 1 were usually brief comments relating to the stimulus points, or extended descriptions of the threat posed by Mary, which were not carefully linked to the conceptual focus of the question. Examiners noted that it was more common for candidates to reach Level 2, however, which suggests a trend identified in both the 2024 and the 2025 series: candidates are likely to be able to provide enough content and focus on the question to move into the next level.

At Level 2, answers remained descriptive and were more likely to focus simply on the stimulus points, describing Mary's legitimate claim to the throne and the plan to place her on it, as well as the Spanish interest in the plot and the threat posed by Phillip II's potential involvement. The limiting factor at Level 2 was most often an inability to clear link the points of content to the concept of 'threat', instead providing a simple statement such as, 'Therefore this was a threat', without a clear explanation of why.

Level 3 answers demonstrated a clearer conceptual focus, providing explanation with some analysis of the threat to both Elizabeth's place on her throne and her life. Answers that moved into Level 4 generally did so on the basis of precise, strong subject knowledge and a sharp focus throughout the response, providing an analytical explanation. At this level, candidates were often able to consider the long-term consequences of the revolt, showing how it contributed to further challenges Elizabeth faced during her reign.

The mark scheme requires candidates to provide three or more points of content in order to achieve the top of Level 3 or access to Level 4. Anecdotally, it was uncommon for candidates to be limited by this ceiling as, at the higher levels, most were able to extrapolate two points of content from the stimulus of 'Mary, Queen of Scots' – for example that her legitimate claim enabled the plotters to propose her for the throne and that her Catholicism motivated them to champion her cause. A less strong approach was to describe the stimulus points as threats in and of themselves, rather than using them as prompts to explain why Elizabeth was threatened. Candidates should be reminded that the stimulus points are most likely to indicate, or be linked to, wider causes.

The most common error continues to be the muddling of Mary, Queen of Scots, with Mary I and therefore claiming she was married to Phillip II or had previously been queen of England. There were also some chronological errors that were possibly a result of candidates reading the later questions: it is possible to link the Revolt with the much-later Spanish Armada, but this requires some very careful analysis and that was not in evidence. A number of responses covered, in detail, Mary's arrival, imprisonment and later

execution, or expressed threats to Elizabeth more generally. While these showed good subject knowledge, it was not rewardable for this question.

While there is no set structure advised for this question, better answers were generally organised around three distinct paragraphs or reasons. The mark scheme for this question does not reward arranging points in a hierarchy, from most to least important, but a number of responses took this approach and it may be helpful practice for organising content to form a judgement in Questions 3 and 4.

2 Explain why the Revolt of the Northern Earls (1569–70) was a threat to Elizabeth I.

(12)

You **may** use the following in your answer:

- Mary, Queen of Scots
- relations between England and Spain

You **must** also use information of your own.

The Revolt of the Northern Earls was a threat to Elizabeth as it encouraged Catholic plots. This was because of the Northern Earls having hope because of the arrival of Mary Queen of Scots. ~~The conflict between Catholics and protestants could be~~ The Northern Earls had their land taken and given to puritans which made them a threat to Elizabeth as England was protestant. ~~Mary Q~~

The Revolt of The Northern Earls showed how much support there was for Mary Queen of Scots. Mary Queen of Scots was a legitimate heir to the throne which was a threat to Elizabeth. Catholics were against the religous settlement as they disliked the clergy wearing vestments. 8,000 clergy of the 10,000 agreed to it and swore

an oath to Elizabeth. The papacy excommunicated Queen Elizabeth and encouraged Catholics in England to become recusants which meant they no longer had to go to Church. There was a 1 shilling fine for not going to Church which Elizabeth did not increase, showing the high level of threat. Mary Queen of Scots was a Catholic figure head who also had relations with Spain which was already angry with England for trading in the new world, making relations worse.

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Examiner Comments

This response demonstrates some explanation and limited analysis. It shows some organisation and implicit links to the question. There is knowledge and understanding in relation to the topic in the question. This response met all the criteria for Level 2, moving to Level 3 for knowledge and understanding, and therefore it was scored at the bottom of Level 3.

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Examiner Tip

As well as beginning each point with a reference to the question, aim to explain why each of the examples given proves your point: in this case, why each example was a threat to Elizabeth.

2 Explain why the Revolt of the Northern Earls (1569–70) was a threat to Elizabeth I.

(12)

You **may** use the following in your answer:

- Mary, Queen of Scots
- relations between England and Spain

You **must** also use information of your own.

The Revolt of the Northern Earls was a threat to Elizabeth because it posed a decrease in the relations between England and Spain. This is because Philip II promised to proude Spain with military aid, ~~marking~~ emphasising the poor relations between England and Spain ~~...~~. In addition, if France were to support the revolt by also giving military aid, Elizabeth would have been over-thrown and replaced with Mary, Queen of Scots.

The Revat of the Northern Earls was also a threat to Elizabeth as they wanted to replace her with Mary, Queen of Scotts. This is because they wanted a

Catholic Queen instead of a Protestant Queen. In addition, Mary, Queen of Scotts was seen as more ~~legitiam~~ legitimate compared to Elizabeth I, this is because Mary, Queen of Scotts, was born within a marriage between Henry the VIII and his wife; unlike Elizabeth who was birthed outside of Henry's VIII marriage, making her claim to the throne significantly weaker. As a result of this, the Revolt of the Northern Earls posed a significant threat to Elizabeth I rein as they wanted to replace her with Mary, Queen of Scotts, and the Northern Earls recieved promises of being provided with support.

Another ~~res~~ reason to why the Revolt of the Northern Earls was a threat to Elizabeth was because it suggested that there may be more ~~result~~ revolts against her. This is because opposition

in regards to Elizabeth may become more desperate to get rid of her, and by the Revolt of the Northern Earls failing, they may get inspired and plan a better revolt. This was a large threat to Elizabeth, as from my own knowledge I know that three more planned revolts followed, although all failed as Walsingham prevented them.

Therefore, the Revolt of the Northern Earls was a significant threat to Elizabeth as it served as inspiration for following plots, and it confirmed the large amount of opposition Elizabeth was facing.

ResultsPlus

Examiner Comments

This response covers several points of content, demonstrating good knowledge and understanding. There are some inaccuracies, but these do not subtract from the good knowledge elsewhere in the answer. Each aspect is explained with some analysis, creating a generally sustained line of reasoning. Although a conclusion is not necessary for this question, the additional paragraph here picks up on the candidate's earlier reference to the possibility of future plots, maintaining the line of reasoning. As this response scored Level 3 against both AO, it scores at the top of the level: 9 marks.

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Examiner Tip

When sharing details of the events of the topic in the question, select these precisely to evidence analysis in relation to the question.

2 Explain why the Revolt of the Northern Earls (1569–70) was a threat to Elizabeth I.

(12)

You **may** use the following in your answer:

- Mary, Queen of Scots
- relations between England and Spain

You **must** also use information of your own.

One reason for the Revolt of the Northern Earls was as a consequence of Catholic religious opposition which threatened Elizabeth's Protestant rule. The revolt of the Northern Earls established Mary, Queen of Scots as a figurehead of Catholic rebellion. This was as Catholics recognised her as a legitimate candidate for the English throne opposed to their perceived illegitimacy of Elizabeth as her parentage was not recognised by the Catholic church. The Revolt's aim to execute Elizabeth and put Mary on the throne pivotally established the threat Mary QofS would continue to oppose immediately as a consequence of her arrival in England in 1568. as legitimate. Additionally the rebels capture of Durham Cathedral and holding of a Catholic mass threatened Elizabeth's religious settlement. The Revolt of the Northern Earls opposed

a Social threat to Elizabeth's reign. The Revolt involved Influential members of the nobility, such as the Duke of Norfolk and the Duke of Northumberland, which Elizabeth relied on to maintain her power. As these catholic members of the nobility were unhappy with Elizabeth's withdrawal of their lands and authority and also the rising power of the gentry such as William Cecil who had not come from ancient families like the Westmorelands. This resulted in a strong political and Social threat to Elizabeth, strengthened by Influential powers opposing her rule. Elizabeth worried this could have lead to Serious rebellions and her execution of the rebels illustrates how Seriously her and her council took this threat.

The Revolt of the Northern Earls also threatened Elizabeth through foreign Involvement. Philip II of Spain Supported the catholic rebels In their uprising and although never

achieved[he] threatened to send Spanish troops. This was significant in establishing the growing tensions between England and Spain as the two countries began to disagree on opposing matters. Thus introducing a threat of invasion to ~~Elizabeth~~ England from the influential military power of Spain.

In conclusion, the Revolt of the Northern Earls was a turning point in the beginning of uprisings in England in Elizabeth's rule. Establishing the opposition to Elizabeth's religious Settlement most significantly. As the rebels aimed to ultimately ~~return~~ restore Catholicism ~~which~~ and as a consequence overthrow Elizabeth.

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Examiner Comments

This answer focuses consistently on the question. There is well-developed analysis in relation to the conceptual focus of the question, organising material around religious, social and foreign threats, and this is supported by precisely selected evidence which is wide-ranging and detailed enough to score in level 4 against AO1. This answer met all the criteria for a Level 4 response and therefore scored full marks. This response does include a conclusion; this did not add to its score.

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Examiner Tip

Provide a clear answer to the question and then select evidence to support that answer. This will help you to construct an analytical explanation.

2 Explain why the Revolt of the Northern Earls (1569–70) was a threat to Elizabeth I. **(12)**

You **may** use the following in your answer:

- Mary, Queen of Scots
- relations between England and Spain

You **must** also use information of your own.

One reason was because it was a domestic rebellion. The rebellion ~~or~~ took placed in the North-East of England, led by the Earl of Northumberland and the Earl of Westmorland who led a march South and protested ~~against~~ by holding an illegal Catholic mass at Durham Cathedral. There was an attempt made to increase the numbers by getting people from Cheshire and Lancashire to join, but the attempt did not go as planned. The fact that it was a domestic revolt meant it was a threat because it clearly displayed the discontent of the people of England, meaning ~~that~~ that Elizabeth's religious settlement had ultimately failed and her control of the country was under scrutiny. Furthermore, this being the first plot may have encouraged others to start plotting too, ~~however to think~~ the revolt potentially being a call for Catholic countries abroad such as Spain

and France to aid the return of Catholicism in England.

Another reason it was a threat is because it was an attempt to marry Mary, Queen of Scots with the Duke of Norfolk. ~~The involved~~ Mary, Queen of Scots was the cousin of Elizabeth I and many Catholics argued that her legitimacy to the throne was more genuine than that of Elizabeth's. ~~Therefore, the involvement of Mary could have driven more Catholics in England to strive harder for rebellion~~ Moreover, Mary had closely tied relationships with France, a very powerful Catholic nation. She was married to the French king's son at a young age and lived most of her life in France, despite being the Queen of Scotland. Hence, this revolt is threatening to Elizabeth I as the people involved greatly increase the likelihood of overseas involvement, which would vastly outnumber the Protestants if an invasion occurred.

Another reason it was threatening to Elizabeth I is because it forced Elizabeth to defend herself, and she did so through the murdering of

approximately 450 Catholics by the army of 10,000 troops that she sent to put the revolt to rest. However, this had inadvertent ~~unfortunate~~ consequences of worsening relations with countries such as Spain and France, as they would have been outraged at the killing of Catholics in England. The Queen of England was swiftly excommunicated from the Catholic Church in 1570, following this mass murdering. Previously, the Pope had wanted to excommunicate Elizabeth I as soon as she came to power in ~~the~~ 1558, however the King of Spain (Philip II) persuaded the Pope not to do so. Therefore, the eventual excommunication after the Northern Earls revolt ~~suggests~~ shows that Elizabeth lost favour with the King of Spain now, as he no longer held back the Pope. This is extremely dangerous for Elizabeth I as Spain are the most powerful nation in the world during this time period, and an invasion by the Spanish could prove costly for Elizabeth I.

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Examiner Comments

This answer also scored full marks and has been included as another example of how content was organised to address the conceptual focus of the question. The candidate states the type of threat at the start of each paragraph and then precisely selects the evidence to support that point.

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Examiner Tip

Where possible, demonstrate detailed and wide-ranging subject knowledge by, for example, including dates and names of key events in the period.

Question 3

Questions 3 and 4 required candidates to analyse a statement related to a debate from the topic and reach an evaluative conclusion. Where candidates achieved Level 4, this evaluation was most often evidenced throughout the essay, demonstrating linked analysis and showing nuance. Conclusions usually involved discussion of the conceptual focus and a weighing up of the different evidence to reach an overall judgement. Most responses included a judgement, but at Levels 2 and 3, this was often stated or repetitive, without supplying justifications or selecting criteria that were relevant to the question. These responses also typically failed to display a running judgement throughout their answer, instead giving evidence relevant to the question and not analysing that evidence in relation to the question.

Question 3 had a significance focus and was the slightly more popular of the two options this summer, though the total number of responses for each option was quite similar. Candidates were asked to evaluate the extent to which financial issues were Elizabeth's main problem on accession. They were provided with the stimulus points the Crown's debt and Elizabeth's legitimacy.

It was very evident that candidates had been carefully taught the extent of Elizabeth's debt, with the figure of £300,000 almost universally cited, compared to her annual income. Stronger answers were able to explain that this was a result of over-spending by previous monarchs, to link it to an inability to fund defence or war and to explain how the debt was eventually solved. Candidates were also almost always able to write in detail about the question of Elizabeth's legitimacy, highlighting the issue of her father's marriage to her mother and the failure of the Catholic church to recognise it as valid.

Other common points of content included Elizabeth's gender and the patriarchal attitudes of the time; the religious divisions in England on her accession; and threats from France. A significant number of responses referred to a threat from Spain, perhaps prompted by other questions on the paper; it should be noted that this is not listed as a problem at the start of her reign in the specification and, indeed, Spain did not initially pose a significant threat, as they were allied in the war against France. It was therefore very rare for candidates to use this content in a way that was rewardable. Similarly, some candidates attempted to highlight poverty as an issue at the start of Elizabeth's reign. Candidates should be discouraged from trying to draw on content found elsewhere in the paper, which is irrelevant.

At Level 1, candidates were often very brief in their description of Elizabeth's problems, or wrote longer answers that were very generalised and lacking in focus on the question. Responses were likely to contain a statement of Elizabeth's problems, eg 'Elizabeth was illegitimate,' without explaining their significance. At this level, responses were distinguished less by incorrect content and more by an absence of explanation, development or any judgements. However, examiners noted that Level 1 responses were fairly rare as most candidates were able to provide enough specific knowledge, for example by quoting the amount of Elizabeth's debt, to move them into Level 2.

At Level 2, candidates were able to relate accurate facts but analysis remained minimal. The most common Level 2 response involved a lot of description of problems faced by Elizabeth; less common, but still noted, was an approach that focused on the significance of each threat without providing any supporting evidence of it. Explanation was likely to be stated at the end of each paragraph, eg 'Therefore, this was a problem' and the judgement was often absent. Some examiners noted that some candidates at this

level wrote long paragraphs that listed multiple problems, leading to a confused line of reasoning.

As candidates moved into Level 3, they were much more likely to have a clear line of reasoning and at this level it was common to see candidates begin to develop criteria for judging 'significance'. There are a number of ways to approach this within the discipline of history, but it was most common for candidates to consider how solvable Elizabeth's various problems were and make a judgement based on this criterion. At this level, candidates were also more likely to begin to consider how problems interacted with each other and incorporate this into their judgements. Analysis is a feature of a Level 3 answer but it is most often included at the end of each paragraph, rather than driving the argument.

At Level 4, candidates were most likely to set up clear criteria for judgement, often in the introduction, which were applied consistently throughout the response. Most commonly these were short-term vs long-term, solvable vs unsolvable or immediate vs underlying, structural threats. Responses were likely to be analytically driven, using language to show the interplay of different issues, rather than working through each problem in turn. Candidates at this level were also more often able to use precise, wide-ranging knowledge to support their arguments.

This most common error was for candidates to consider Elizabeth's problems throughout her reign, rather than at the start. For example, while it might be reasonable to use later Catholic plots when making a judgement about the longevity of the problem of religious division, Catholic plots themselves were not a problem for Elizabeth when she became queen and this content, though often included, was not often rewardable.

Indicate which question you are answering by marking a cross in the box ☒. If you change your mind, put a line through the box ☒ and then indicate your new question with a cross ☒.

Chosen question number: **Question 3** ☒ **Question 4** ☒

I partially agree that financial weakness was Elizabeths main problem when she became queen in 1558. When Elizabeth first became queen she already had to pay a £300,000 debt to the crown due to Mary and her own desicions. This meant ~~that Elizabeth had to sell land~~ As well as this Elizabeth had to pay a yearly fee of £97000 just for being queen and having the crown. This meant that she had to sell crown owned land to pay her debts. With the help of her Privy council she was able to pay her debts. Therefore I partially agree financial weakness was Elizabeths main problem.

Elizabeths legitmacy became an issue for her when becoming queen. Many believed she was not the rightful heir to the crown due to her religon as well as her being a women. People back then believed women were weak so having a women rule the country would not work. Elizabeth however proved many of these people wrong making them change there views. Consequently

Elizabeths legitamacy was an issue for her, the same amount as her financial issues.

In addition to this Elizabeths religion became a problem for her. Elizabeth was protestant and many people in Britain were catholic which caused conflict giving her not much support. Puritans also believed she was not protestant enough. This made it diffficult to control a country where both religions did not support her reign entirly.

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Examiner Comments

This Level 3 response demonstrates accurate and relevant information. An explanation is given with some analysis: this is particularly strong in the first paragraph but less sustained in the later paragraphs: this is a common approach in mid-scoring answers, where candidates are more likely to describe some content and then attempt to relate it back to the question. A judgement is asserted at the end of the answer. The quality of the work when measured against AO1 is strong enough for this response to score in Level 3, but the quality of the work against the two AO2 strands is weaker, creating a 'best fit' of 10 marks.

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Examiner Tip

When making a judgement about significance, develop specific criteria for making the judgement and apply these throughout the answer, rather than making generalisations about relative importance.

Indicate which question you are answering by marking a cross in the box ☒. If you change your mind, put a line through the box ☒ and then indicate your new question with a cross ☒.

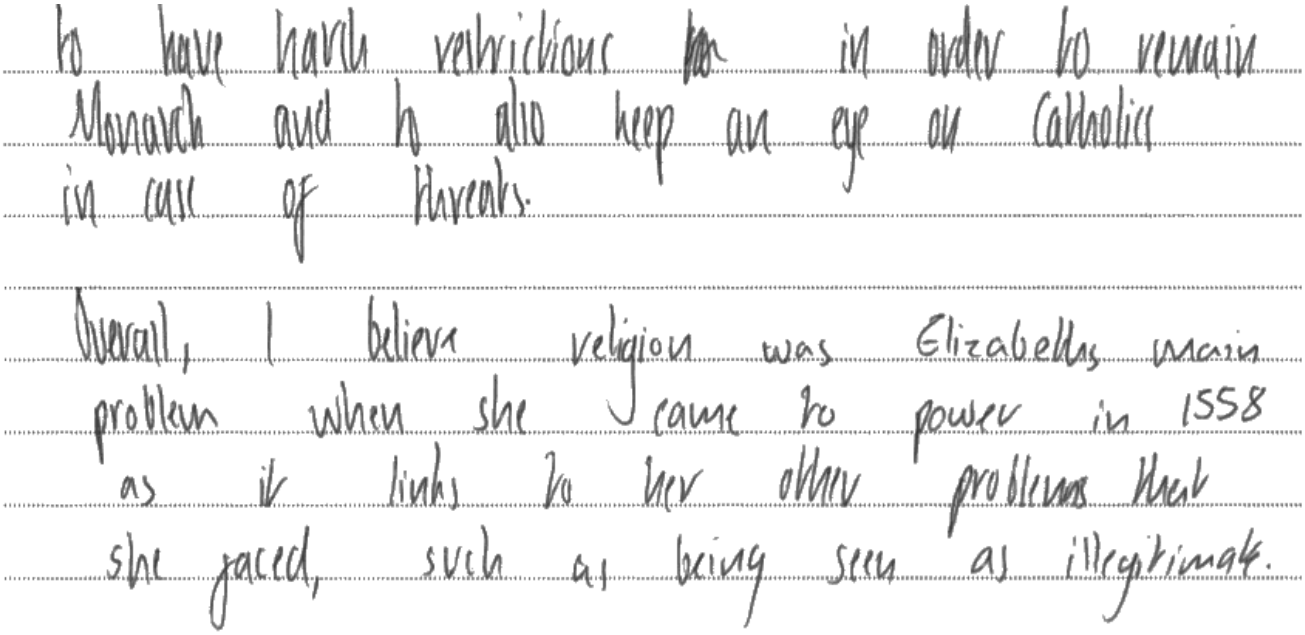
Chosen question number: **Question 3** ☒ **Question 4** ☒

Some may agree that financial weakness was Elizabeth's main problem when she became queen in 1558. This was due to England being in a vunerable position. As the country was financially struggling, they were unable to defend themselves if conflict occurred. This meant Elizabeth had to try and build up the economy again for her own protection and to prevent the country from being invaded by others. Elizabeth's financial weakness was due to the effects of wars her father had got involved in. This caused a strain on England since Henry VII was wasting money on weaponry. Furthermore, this means that some will agree that her main problem when she came to the throne in 1558 was financial weakness as it put England at risk of invasion and unable to fight against conflict.

Some may disagree that financial weakness was Elizabeth's main problem when she became queen in 1558, this was because many people deemed her illegitimate. People viewed her as illegitimate since she was female. Many believed that queen's should be married and give their power to their husband. This led to many expecting

Elizabeth to get married, However, Elizabeth didn't want to give up her power and remained unmarried. This was a new concept to people and they feared what may happen. Many also saw her as illegitimate because she was the child of her father's second marriage; which led to him being ex-communicated by the Pope. This led to many not believing she was a rightful heir as God would disagree with her position. Also, Elizabeth was only written into the line of succession on her father's death bed so many assumed she persuaded him and his word shouldn't be taken literally since he was dying.

Another reason some may disagree that her main problem was financial weakness is because of Elizabeths religion. Elizabeth was a ~~catholic~~ protestant. Catholics were unhappy with this since they wanted a catholic leader and country. This led to many conspiring against Elizabeth and forming plots against her to attempt to overthrow or kill her. Religion also damaged her relationship further with foreign countries as many were catholic. This meant they would support attempts to overthrow or kill her. This meant that Elizabeth needed



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Examiner Comments

This Level 3 response demonstrates accurate and relevant information, showing good knowledge and understanding. There is explanation with analysis and a judgement is given, with some justification. This is a strong Level 3 response but does not move into Level 4 due to the quality of the work at AO2: this is a good example of explanation with some analysis, as opposed to analytical explanation.

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Examiner Tip

Consider the points you will be making throughout the answer and aim to organise each paragraph around one of those points, rather than describing relevant content and then analysing the link to the question at the end of the paragraph.

Indicate which question you are answering by marking a cross in the box ☒. If you change your mind, put a line through the box ☒ and then indicate your new question with a cross ☒.

Chosen question number: **Question 3** ☒ **Question 4** ☒

It is arguable that financial weakness was a significant problem to Elizabeth when she became queen in 1558, however, there are many other problems, such as legitimacy, marriage and gender, which she faced that was more problematic and the main problem, rather than financial weakness. Therefore, I strongly disagree with the statement.

Firstly, when Elizabeth became Queen in 1558, she inherited a debt of £300,000 from her half sister, Mary I (Bloody Mary), which placed England at a very poor financial situation. As a result of this, Elizabeth in order to pay this back was unable to raise rents as they were fixed; she couldn't rely on the Parliament as they would become too powerful and £300,000 was a huge, excessive amount of money at the time. Thus, Queen Elizabeth faced many problems regarding how she will pay this debt back. She ended up implementing custom duties, which are taxes from trade; she implemented subsidies, which were special, additional taxes that had to be agreed by the Parliament and she collected feudal dues (rent) from crown land. It was only by 1585 that she raised £600,000 to pay back the debt and reserve the extra £300,000. This meant it took her more than 25 years to pay back this debt. Therefore, the multiple problems Elizabeth faced regarding paying back this inherited debt and the prolonged years

that took the debt to be paid back, made financial weakness, the most major problem for Elizabeth when she became Queen in 1558.

However, even though financial weakness was a major problem and lasted long years, there were other problems that Queen Elizabeth faced continuously throughout her reign, such as marriage. For example, Queen Elizabeth constantly faced immense pressure to marry and produce an heir to the English throne, because it was believed that Queens could not lead armies to battles and thus a king was required and by producing an heir, civil war can be prevented. However all the royal men of her rank were foreign princes, who were unpopular and could easily side-line and overshadow her presence, because in England, king has more power and authority over a queen. This meant that Queen Elizabeth may lose her power and dominance as queen in England to a random, foreign prince that is not the rightful heir to the throne. Thus, due to fear of overshadowing, Queen Elizabeth rejected marriage and her dismissal of marriage resulted in immense pressures placed on her throughout her reign and criticisms remarked on her. Therefore, the arising ~~comments~~ criticisms and hatred regarding her not marrying, resulted in marriage being a constant, main issue to Queen Elizabeth.

Although, it is arguable that financial weakness was the main problem when Elizabeth became Queen, because she was unable to make any strategical solutions immediately due to many actions already implemented which made it difficult for her to solve. For instance, in the coins that were used in England, Henry VIII had completed coin debasement during his reign. This meant that the amount of silver in each coin was significantly reduced, resulting in the value of the coin to decrease. Thus, the value of England's money itself was extremely low. This made financial weakness as the main problem for Queen Elizabeth, because she was unable to change the amount of silver in the coins as they were already debased and even if she wanted to, she had to proceed with discussions with parliament first and she didn't want to rely on the parliament too much as it would make them powerful. Thus, this made it difficult for her to pay the £300,000 debt, because even if she collected a lot of money, the value would be lower. Therefore, coin debasement and the decrease in the value of money also made financial weakness the main and major problem as it was difficult for Elizabeth to pay back the debts.

On the other hand, even though coin debasement was a problem to Elizabeth, using her influence and the power of the parliament, she can bring change, although she cannot change her legitimacy. For instance, Henry VIII's annulment to Catherine of Aragon was considered unlawful by the Catholic Church of England and so was not accepted. Thus, Queen Elizabeth, who was born

to Henry VIII and Anne Boleyn (2nd wife) was considered as an illegitimate, bastard child. This meant that Catholics, who were the mostly populated in England, viewed Elizabeth as illegitimate and not the rightful heir to the throne. This resulted in potential threat for Elizabeth of Catholic rebellions. Therefore, her legitimacy was a major problem for Elizabeth when she became queen.

To conclude, I strongly disagree with the statement that financial weakness was the main problem for Elizabeth I, because even though her inherited debt of £300,000 and coin debasement imposed different difficulties for Elizabeth to pay back the debt, by 1585, she paid it back and she was able to restore finance. However, she faced other continuous problems, such as gender, making them her major and main problems. For example, in the Bible, it says that women must be subordinate to men and Queen Elizabeth is not fit to rule, because she is a women, who is meant to cook, clean and obey. Thus, these gender restrictions expressed and forced upon her, makes these constant problems the main problems rather than financial weakness.

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Examiner Comments

This candidate has demonstrated wide-ranging knowledge of this topic, including detailed facts to support an analytical explanation. Aspects of content are evaluated throughout to provide a clear and compelling judgement in relation to the focus of the question, concluding that financial weakness was not Elizabeth's main problem as it was one she was able to solve. The judgement is fully supported and there is a clear line of reasoning throughout the response. This response scored full marks.

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Examiner Tip

Target the top mark on this question by including a clear line of argument that runs from your introduction through to your conclusion, selecting evidence precisely to support your analysis.

Question 4

Question 4 focused on the second-order concept of causation, asking candidates to evaluate how far poor planning was the main reason for the English victory over the Spanish Armada. The stimulus points were the leadership of the Duke of Medina Sidonia, and the use of fire ships.

It was common for candidates to extrapolate from the stimulus points and many were able to link the leadership of Medina Sidonia with poor planning on the part of the Spanish, while using the fire ships among other examples of English tactics that led to their victory. Going beyond the stimulus points, candidates often wrote about the poor weather, Drake's raid on Cadiz and the innovations in ship building. It was noted that there was some very specific and detailed knowledge of battle tactics and the relative merits of the English vs the Spanish ships.

At Level 1, candidates provided only vague responses, for example referring to Medina Sidonia's seasickness or identifying that ships were made of wood. Responses at this level were brief and narrative, lacking detail and judgement. Candidates often made assertions that were less relevant to the conceptual focus of the question. This meant there was little to no engagement with why a factor caused Spanish defeat.

In Level 2, responses were often descriptive, telling the story of the Spanish Armada chronologically, which little consideration of the reasons why it was defeated. Candidates were more likely to provide accurate descriptive evidence at this level, for example describing Medina Sidonia's inexperience or the impact of the fire ships, but judgement was likely to be asserted rather than justified. It was also common at this level for responses to lack a comparative structure, instead listing different events or factors.

Level 3 responses were characterised by solid, accurate knowledge. Candidates were able to describe different aspects of Spanish planning and get quite specific about different tactics used by the English to tackle each one, for example destroying the crescent formation. Indeed, examiners noted that AO1 was often very strong at this level and the limiting assessment objective was AO2, with candidates often presenting material as separate, self-contained points with some judgement about their impact, rather than creating a clear line of reasoning. As a result of this, judgements at Level 3 were often asserted or repetitions of points previously made, rather than based on clear criteria.

These criteria were evidenced in level 4 answers, where they were often presented in the introduction and applied throughout to reach a reasoned judgement: this is evidence of candidates thinking through their responses carefully before beginning to write. Knowledge at this level was detailed and nuanced: candidates would, for example, write about the impact of the Raid on Cadiz on the supplies available to the Armada, or the Spanish failure to secure deep water ports preventing the rendezvous with the Duke of Parma. This content was used to support analysis, rather than simply display knowledge. The best answers considered the interplay of causes and were able to make a judgement about short-term and long-term causes, or decisive vs contributory causes.

Common misconceptions included confusing fire ships with a new type of fast ship or believing that they set the whole Spanish fleet ablaze. There was also some muddling between the two sides: some candidates suggested that Drake commanded the Spanish forces, while others identified the fire ships as a Spanish weapon. In terms of approach, perhaps the single greatest issue was candidates knowing too much: in some cases, so much content was shared that it limited the time available for analysis.

Candidates should be reminded that 'precisely selected evidence' is a feature of Level 4 answers.

Indicate which question you are answering by marking a cross in the box ☒. If you change your mind, put a line through the box ☒ and then indicate your new question with a cross ☒.

Chosen question number: **Question 3** ☒ **Question 4** ☒

I ~~mostly~~ slightly agree since the captain of the ship (the duke of medina sidonia) was seasick and inexperienced, and since they went into english waters to fight, they didn't have nutritious meals like meat (but the english did since they could take trips back to land for food.

Although, I can disagree ~~slightly~~ too since the weather also hindered the spanish - the weather was dismal: rain, high speed winds and that on the ocean was incredibly difficult to deal with, especially when they having to take a different path to get to their destination due to that and ocean currents.

ALSO, the English had invented Galleons ~~(ship~~ which were a type of ship which was smaller, more versatile, quicker and they had long

range canons on them whilst the spanish had big ships that had to get close to the english ships in order to attack and do any damage.

I can also disagree due to newer exploration technology in England; the astrolabe for example helped with direction.

overall, to conclude, I mostly disagree since English technology and the weather also hindered the spanish alongside their poor planning

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Examiner Comments

This response scored in Level 2 across all strands of the mark scheme. There is some knowledge and understanding, but this is vague in places. There is limited analysis, with some explanation, lacking in development and an asserted judgement at the end. This is a borderline response that is close to moving into Level 3; however, the AO2 explanation is not strong enough to demonstrate sufficient understanding of how the points of content selected led to the defeat of the Armada, and therefore the response remains in Level 2, at 8 marks.

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Examiner Tip

Make regular references back to the question through your answer to ensure that your content fits the conceptual focus. Writing an initial plan may also help with this.

I disagree that the main reason for English victory was poor planning by the Spanish but it was due to the use of fire ships from the English was also important. The English took advantage of the strong tides and sent fire ships towards the Armada. The cresent formation of the ships was quickly broken up by the fire ships some of the ships even ending up lost at sea. Due to the ships being lost and unorganised it made it easier to attack the Spanish ships and have a victory for the English.

However some would still agree that the main reason was due to poor planning. Alot of the Spanish men had a lack of knowledge and mostly relied on having the ships as an advantage. ~~and~~ the Spanish just charged into invasion despite

barely even having something planned. Phillip II decided to put the Duke of Medina Sidonia in charge of leading the Armada even though he had no knowledge on what to do. People see this as the main reason because they were so clueless England had the advantage as they were prepared for the Armada to happen due to information from Francis Drake.

Although poor planning was an important reason I still disagree that it was the most important reason as they had a poor ship design. The Spanish were able to create big ships to use but in this case that was not a good thing. The ships being bigger made them much more heavier therefore hard to manouver in the rough tides giving England the upper hand once again. They also had heavier cannons

So the big boats were made even heavier. However England had light, fast loading cannons so they could easily attack back on the Spanish as they were coming close enough to be reached with a shot from a cannon. Their quick fire would not have been easily dodged because they created big, heavy ships.

In conclusion I disagree that poor planning was the reason as there are other really important factors to consider when talking about failure from the Spanish side.

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Examiner Comments

There are several accurate points of content in this response, demonstrating good subject knowledge. There is explanation with some analysis, though the response lacks a strong, sustained line of reasoning. The judgement is given with some justification, but less explicit criteria. This response scored in Level 3 across all strands of the mark scheme and therefore scored 12 marks overall.

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Examiner Tip

Move a response beyond Level 3 by deploying precise knowledge to support your analysis, rather than explaining the points of content and adding analysis afterwards.

Indicate which question you are answering by marking a cross in the box ☒. If you change your mind, put a line through the box ☒ and then indicate your new question with a cross ☒.

Chosen question number: **Question 3** ☒ **Question 4** ☒

I Agree to a lesser extent that Spanish poor planning was a reason for the Victory of England during the Spanish Armada. Although Undoubtly poor planning by the Spanish was a contributing factor for their loss. for example, Philip's appointment of Duke Medina Sidonia was poor as the Duke had no naval experience but was chosen rather for his 'good catholic' position in Society. This put Spain at a disadvantage against the experienced English Commanders of Sir Francis Drake and Lord Seymour. As a Consequence additionally of poor planning Spain's letter by sea were an Ineffective form of communication. Leading to troops in the Netherlands not being aware of the Armada in the Channel until 1 week after the Armadas departure. Resulting in a Significant advantage for England as

Spanish reinforcements were delayed.

However, I strongly agree it could be recognised that the work of English Privateers and Milita was an Influential factor in England's Success. For example, by Singeing the King's beard, Sir Francis Drake attacked the Spanish naval base at Cadiz. Which damaged many Spanish Supplies and Ships and ~~additionally~~ as a consequence delayed the Spanish Armada by a year allowing England to better prepare.

Additionally, Robert Dudley and his army prevented Spain from capturing any deep water ports in the Flushing in the Netherlands. Which resulted in when Spanish armada did arrive to collect the troops they could not dock close enough to for troops to board the boats Strengthening England's Strength.

furthermore, I believe the use of English fireships at Gravelines was andly

Significant reason for the success of England against the Armada. This is because the fireships broke the Armada's Crescent formation which was a key Strength for the armada. Additionally they destroyed Spanish artillery and troop morale at little cost to the English giving England an additional advantage. The Ships Spain had remaining were slower and less maneoverable than English galleons this lead to Spain being unable to execute their tactic of close on board ship fighting as England used long range artillery to keep out of range. Destroying another Spanish weakness.

Ultimately, I believe the English victory over the Armada was as a result of tactical English military Strengths. Although it can be recognised that Spain's poor planning Contributed Significantly to the effectiveness of England's tactics, Such as ~~long range~~ guerilla warfare at Sea which Francis

Drake was experienced In. However the most important factor D the English attacks which lead to a lack of Spanish provisions as this directly weakened the Armada and their ability to fight.

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Examiner Comments

This response demonstrates wide-ranging and detailed knowledge of the reasons why the English were able to defeat the Spanish Armada. The candidate develops a sophisticated line of reasoning, grouping points of content into a coherent structure. Criteria are applied and justified in the conclusion: this is a valid approach. The analytical explanation throughout, coupled with the precise understanding demonstrated, brings this response to the top of the level.

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Examiner Tip

Writing a Level 4 response requires you to know the content really well, so that you can make precise selections and group different points of content under broad headings.

Paper Summary

Based on performance in the 2026 series, candidates are advised to:

- Revise all sections of the specification, ensuring secure coverage of both breadth and depth.
- Learn and practise using topic-specific vocabulary, including key terms linked to second-order concepts.
- Check chronology carefully -- accurate sequencing is essential for a strong performance.
- Use time effectively—Q1a and Q1b require concise responses; over-writing can reduce time available for extended questions.
- Attempt every question -- even partial knowledge can secure marks.
- Include precise evidence wherever possible, for example names, dates, statistics and specific events. These strengthen AO1 and support analytical explanation.
- For the 16-mark question, plan an argument that directly evaluates the statement and sustains a clear line of reasoning throughout.
- Use paragraphs to organise ideas clearly, supporting coherence and progression.
- If additional space is needed, continue on a separate sheet and ensure it is clearly labelled and attached to the B booklet only.
- Candidates typing responses or using additional paper should complete the B and P papers in separate documents, as required.

Grade boundaries

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